The Spirit of God Moved upon the Face of the Waters: Orthodox Holiness and the Natural World

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In the *Prima Vita* of the nineteenth-century Russian saint known as Herman of Alaska, this passage occurs:

> In the middle of Spruce Island [a tiny island a few miles out to sea from Kodiak, Alaska] a little river runs from the mountain into the sea. There were always large logs of driftwood at the mouth of this river, continuously brought there by storms. In the springtime when the river fish would appear, the Elder would dig in the sand so that the river could pass by and the fish in the sea would hasten up the river. "It would happen that Apa would say: 'Go and get a fish from the river,'" said Aliaga. Father Herman used to feed birds with dried fish and they in great number would nest near his cell. Under his cell there lived ermines. This little animal, after giving birth to its litter, is unapproachable, yet the Elder would feed them with his own hands. "Wasn't that really a miracle we have seen!" said his disciple Ignatius. Father Herman was also seen feeding the bears. "With the death of the Elder both the birds and the beasts disappeared; even the garden would not give forth crop if someone were to care for it willingly," asserted Ignatius.[1]

Ignatius's final assertion offers us our starting point. When St. Herman died, the birds and beasts suddenly vanished, and the garden became all at once and completely fruitless. What are we to make of this?

In 1922, Fr. Pavel Florensky published in Russia his last theological work, *Iconostasis.* Born in 1882, Fr. Pavel had been, since his ordination in 1911, a leading figure in Russia's extraordinary movement in religious philosophy, a movement whose roots lay in the direct experience of nineteenth-century

Russian monasticism, an experience that had led the novelist Fyodor Dostoevsky in the 1860s and 1870s to create his two final masterpieces, *Demons* and *The Brothers Karamazov*.[2] Thus, the flowering of this movement of Russian religious philosophy can be best understood as an attempt to do two things: to actualize in Orthodox practice the literary images of Orthodox holiness that Dostoevsky in his novels had fashioned, and to shift the whole of Western philosophy and intellectual culture onto a ground of Orthodox practice. Imagine, for a moment, Germany's Kant and Hegel meeting Dostoevsky's Bishop Tikhon and Father Zosima—and becoming all at once Orthodox: following fully all the fasts, attending joyfully all the services, devoutly praying all the prayers. And then imagine what Hegel and Kant—after, say, a dozen years of Orthodox ascetic practice—would then write as works of philosophy. Such works would resemble—just imaginably—what Florensky actually wrote. Thus, between Dostoevsky's death in 1880 and the Bolshevik revolution in 1917, Russian intellectual and spiritual articulation was guided by the voices of religious philosophy—voices to be violently drowned out, of course, by the strident clamor of the triumphant Marxist ones. Only now are their voices once again coming clear to us.

In 1922, Fr. Pavel in his *Iconostasis* explores the significance of the icon: its philosophic depth, its spiritual history, its empirical technique. Late in the book, Fr. Pavel distinguishes in icon painting between the painting of the *face* and the painting of everything else in the icon—"body, garments, rooms, buildings, trees, rocks, and so on."[3] He then says this:

> Painting the face is called *lichnoe* while painting everything else is termed *dolichnoe*; and by *lik* [the Russian root of both words] is understood those secondary organs of expressiveness (i.e., the "little countenances") of hands and feet. In this division of the icon's whole content into the processes of *lichnoe* and *dolichnoe* we can plainly see the Greek patristic understanding of existence being divided into *man* and *nature*; a division wherein each is at once distinct and inseparable from the other; hence, it is a division expressing the primordial paradisiacal harmony of inwardness and outwardness.[4]

The painting of garments is thus entirely distinct from the painting of faces, yet, in the icon, the garments become *secondarily expressive*, he says, and thereby inseparable from the icon's whole content. It is as if the illumined *face* in the icon makes everything else achieve genuine expressiveness in that face's light. In this way, then, the *inseparability* of these two activities in icon painting illustrates what Panayiotis Nellas, in his magnificent book *Deification in Christ*, describes as our paradisiacal beginning: the bringing together

of all things into the hands of man in order that man may then give all things back to God. "This," says Nellas, "is man's natural state in the image of God; this is his natural function, his natural work and goal."[5] We may thus say that, in Florensky's terms, the painting of the world (the *dolichnoe*) manifests the way wherein we see how man restores the world to God in the act of love, while the painting of the face (the *lichnoe*) enacts the way wherein the iconic face illumines the whole of the natural world.

From this perspective, we can return to the passage from St. Herman's *Prima Vita* and now say this: when the Elder feeds the otherwise unapproachable ermine and her newborns, or when he lifts up his hands with bits of dried fish in them and all the birds come, or when his fingers gently touch the bear's mouth, he is expressing the simultaneous inseparability of and distinction between the two realms of man and nature. And just as in the icon, where the trees and rocks are given a secondary expressiveness by the iconic face, so, too, St. Herman here restores to ermine and bear something like a paradisiacal glory—and in this moment the world becomes icon through the light of St. Herman's face.

The question, then, is *how*. How is the natural world made iconic? And how does the iconic face illumine the natural world?

Earlier in *Iconostasis*, Florensky distinguishes between what he calls the human *face* and what he terms the human *countenance*. Once again, here is Fr. Pavel's discussion of the point:

> By face (*litzo*), we mean that which we see in ordinary daylight consciousness, that which we see as the recognizable appearance of the real world; and we can speak . . . of all natural things and creations with whom we are in conscious relation as having a face: as, for example, we speak of the face of nature. Face, we may thus say, is nearly synonymous with the word *appearance*—meaning, however, *appearance to daylight consciousness*. But in saying this, we must not deprive the word *face* of all objective reality; rather, we must see in *face* a boundary between subjectivity and objectivity. . . . On the other hand, the countenance (*lik*) of a thing manifests its ontological reality. In Genesis, *the image of God* is differentiated from *the likeness of God*; and long ago, the Holy Tradition of the Church explained that the *image of God* must be understood as the ontologically actual gift of God, as the spiritual ground of each created person; whereas the *likeness of God* must be understood as the potentiality to achieve spiritual perfection: that is, to construct the *likeness of God* in ourselves from that totality of our empirical personalities called the *image of God*, to incarnate in the flesh of

> our personality the hidden inheritance of our sacred likeness to God: and to reveal this incarnation in our *face* (*litzo*):. . . and our *face* (*litzo*) becomes a *countenance* (*lik*). (51–52)

This is, I submit, an extraordinary understanding. Central to Orthodox asceticism is the work of opening space in ourselves between our desires and our actions. If every desire we have triggers an action we take—if, for example, every time I feel a touch of hunger I put something in my mouth—then two disastrous effects follow. First, our desires soon come to steer all our relations with the natural world, in that the world becomes the materialization of all our desires and all our hungers—and, in that sense, the world is *dematerialized* into these desires and hungers. The second effect that follows when we fail to open space between our desires and our actions is that our selfhood becomes, in time, something like an entirely closed system of autonomous desire and autonomous satisfaction, a system wherein (once again) the natural world is dematerialized and unmade. The results of both effects are fear and depression: the fear born of the fact that our autonomous powers are indeed frail and crumbling; the depression born of the fact that we have willed our own desolation. Dostoevsky's portraits of such fear and depression in his novel *Demons* starkly depict the final goal of such states: suicide. And, in Florensky's terms, when such psychic states are reached, our face becomes not a *countenance* but a *mask* (*lichina*). Florensky writes: "Dostoevsky well understood this process in his character Stavrogin [in *Demons*], whose face had become a stony mask and no longer a real face: such is one of the steps in the disintegration of personality" (56).

Only Orthodox ascetic practice, Florensky holds, can transform our face into our countenance. And when we do so, he says, "all natural things and creations with whom we are in conscious relation" may be spoken of "as having a face." Thus we may say that when St. Herman bent down to feed the mother ermine, his long ascetic practice of distinguishing between his own desires and the natural world had resulted in his face having become a countenance. And when the ermine looked up at St. Herman, her face was illumined by the saint's iconic countenance. All of nature was at that moment achieving a countenance: such is the consequence of all Orthodox asceticism.

In the second century B.C., the Septuagint translators came to the second verse of Genesis: "The spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters." The word they chose for the Hebrew *paném* (face) was the Greek *prosopon*. This is the same word they used for the divine countenance of God. And a half-millennium later, this is also the word first used to mean

the very *Person* of God: so essential is countenance to personhood. In its movement of creatively self-emptying love, the Holy Spirit of God bestows countenance upon the waters. And when we enter into that conscious relation to the created world known as Orthodox ascetic practice, we also—in the likeness of God—bestow countenance upon the created world, and thus we come to experience directly the way wherein the created world is an icon of God. We may thus say that our ascetic practice is (to use Florensky's term) *dolichnoe.*

One further step. Quickened into being by the Holy Spirit of God, the true countenance of the natural world is thus *accomplished* and fulfilled by our exercise of our divinely given sovereignty over it. And our sovereignty over the natural world has, we may say, only one true expression: the action of self-giving love born of holy ascesis, an action by which each of us receives the likeness of God granted by the Holy Spirit. As Vladimir Lossky so beautifully tells us in his *Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church:*

> The Holy Spirit effaces Himself, as Person, before the created persons to whom He will appropriate grace. In Him the will of God is no longer external to ourselves: it confers grace inwardly, manifesting itself within our very person in so far as our human will remains in accord with the divine will and co-operates with it in acquiring grace, in making it *ours*. . . . This divine Person, now unknown, not having His image in another *Hypostasis*, will manifest Himself in deified persons: for the multitude of the saints will be His image.[6]

In the same way, the sanctified human person confers something of grace on the natural world in his or her action of sovereign ascetic love, thereby fulfilling the Divine Image in the natural world and restoring the creation to the Creator.

Lossky further tells us that the "divine Persons do not themselves assert themselves, but one bears witness to another. It is for this reason that St. John Damascene said that 'the Son is the image of the Father, and the Spirit the image of the Son.' It follows that the third *Hypostasis* of the Trinity is the only one not having His image in another Person. The Holy Spirit, as person, remains unmanifested, hidden, concealing Himself in His very appearing" (159–160). That is, until the saints bear witness to Him. What I am suggesting, then, is that in the same way we as persons must somehow, through our ascesis, conceal ourselves, remain hidden, so that the world we have been given to rule may bear witness to the Likeness in us, who are witnessing to the Holy Spirit. The natural world will bear witness to us whether we are trying to be holy or not; far better that we should try to be holy.

Once more, let us return to the final sentence in the passage from St. Herman's *Prima Vita*. When the birds and beasts vanish and the garden becomes fruitless, then we may say (in Florensky's terms) that the face of nature has, for the moment, become a darkened mask. That is, with the disappearance of St. Herman's countenance, the reality of Orthodox asceticism has—in this place, at this moment—vanished. And the effect of such a vanishing is to cease what Nellas calls the bringing together of all things in man so as to return all things to God. For only the human person possesses this capacity to restore the natural world to God because only the human can enter into that Orthodox ascetic practice wherein face (*litzo*) becomes countenance (*lik*).

Such vanishing also touches another issue central to Russian religious philosophy: incorruptibility. Dostoevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov* beautifully explores this issue in the death of Father Zosima. But Dostoevsky is, in turn, drawing from an experience central to all Russian religious history: the death of St. Sergius of Radonezh.

On the morning of September 25, 1392, at the age of seventy-eight, a very frail Father Sergius attended the Liturgy in the Monastery of the Holy Trinity, which he had founded some twenty years earlier. After the Liturgy, he spoke a brief farewell in his cell to his fellow monks. And then he very peacefully died. The fourteenth-century account says that, at the moment of his death, his body gave off an intensely sweet fragrance that filled the cell and the whole hallway beyond. All hearts lifted, the account says, at the sweet intensity of this heavenly odor. Father Sergius was buried next to the Church he had built, some of it with his own hands.

Then the miracles began. Many visiting his grave were healed of all kinds of afflictions and illnesses: the blind could see; the lame walked and danced. Some thirty years passed, and then his body was exhumed by the Church so that his bones might become relics. Then the great miracle was revealed. His body was perfectly preserved, dressed in the clothes he had been buried in, still fresh and intact. His body was then placed in the monastery church, where it remains to this day, still incorrupt. Here is the heart of Orthodox Russia. And here is where, in 1922, Fr. Pavel Florensky wrote *Iconostasis*.

What, then, are we to make of the incorrupt body of St. Sergius?

By way of approaching a response, I want to tell you of my visit, in August 1988, to this place. I traveled to Russia as part of a small Orthodox group on pilgrimage to honor the first thousand years of Orthodoxy in Russia. The Soviet regime would not fall until August 1991. Hence, in the summer of 1988, we were very much in the hands of the Soviet In-tourist Bureau, that branch of the Communist state which firmly controlled the activities of all

tourists, especially U.S. citizens—particularly U.S. citizens identified as Eastern Orthodox Christians. Our In-tourist guides thus assumed at every opportunity the right to speak to us about the sunny truths of atheism and the dark lies of religion. Even the tour-bus drivers never missed an opportunity, raising their voices to carry to the back of the bus where I and my tour friend Elizabeth (whose Russian was better than mine) always sat, she quietly translating for me.

So it was that on August 23, 1988, we came by bus to what was then called Zagorsk. For the hour's drive from Moscow, the day's driver had been especially loud in his harsh laughter about the saint "who couldn't even rot right." That's how contemptible St. Sergius was. Our American guide and organizer, Masha Tkachuk, stopped our driver's stream of abuse with a single question: "Have you ever seen the inside of the church where St. Sergius's body lies?" "Well, no, of course not," he spluttered, brought up short. "Come in with us," Masha said quietly. For the final ten miles, he was silent, and as we all got off the bus, he would not look at any of us. Masha spoke to him once more: "Come," she said. He shook his head, a decided "No."

On that hot summer afternoon our little group joined the hundreds of pilgrims crowded in the church. It took me a minute to realize that everyone was silent, and in another minute I identified the faint sound of voices from the front of the church as the voices of Orthodox monks softly chanting words I was still too far away to catch. People in twos and threes were exiting along the walls, so we began to inch slowly forward, toward the point where the monks—and two of them I now could see—were chanting in turns as they faced each other over the ends of a low table. In another few minutes, I would begin to catch the Slavonic forms of biblical names I knew from the Psalms.

Then it became clear. The monks were standing not at a low table but at the head and foot of a coffin, and over the entire coffin was placed a glass dome maybe ten inches high. "Some dozen yards all around the casket there was a field of humming energy that was almost perceptible light," I wrote in my journal that night. Here was the body of St. Sergius of Radonezh.

All the pilgrims were, one by one, going up three steps to the area where St. Sergius lay, kissing the dome above the saint and then saying a brief prayer or petition. After a minute or so, another monk would lightly touch the pilgrim's shoulder or arm, then help him or her to another set of three steps leading back down to the church floor. Already another pilgrim would be at the saint's tomb.

As I came down the exit steps, I was startled to see our tour-bus driver standing against the wall and watching. I could see tears streaming down his

face. He was softly shaking his head and saying something. I just caught his words: "I didn't understand, I didn't understand." His eyes were filled with the unshakable joy of beauty.

That evening, in our Moscow hotel, he asked the priest in our group if he would baptize him, and our priest assented. He took the name Sergius as his Orthodox name.

I offer this experience as a tiny narrative icon of incorruptibility. I will remember all my life the depth of the *presence* of St. Sergius. This is what our driver encountered in the monastery church that day. And this presence does not corrupt because—to use Florensky's terms—St. Sergius had, through long ascetic practice of fasting and prayer, so transfigured his body that his face had become iconic countenance and his whole presence therefore had achieved the condition of iconic *dolichnoe*: the condition of unceasing iconic expressiveness. Such a condition brings back an accord between man and nature that makes concrete the original relationship lost in Eden and restored only in ascetic practice: the harmony wherein the human presence ennobles everything and everyone in creation through the action of self-giving love. What Florensky calls the "bad infinity of unrestraint" is "cut at its very root" by ascetic practice, and the ascetic achieves, says Florensky, "an incorruptible body and an incorruptible mind."[7] "And even non-spiritual people," Florensky continues, "receive from this ascetic the strength for a better relation to creation" (*PG*, 200). This is the strength that our tour-bus driver beautifully encountered that day in August 1988.

Christ says in the Gospel: "Let your light so shine before all, that all may see your good works, and glorify your Father who is in heaven" (Mt. 5:16). Florensky notes that the phrase "your good works" is not to be understood as philanthropy and morality but, he says, as "literally, 'the works of your beauty,'" a phrase, he continues, that means, "above all, the illumined face whose beauty arises from the dispersal of inward light into the outward appearance; and the light of this face so overwhelms those who behold it that they glorify the heavenly Father whose image corresponds to this brightness before them" (*PG*, 57). St. Herman's compassionate heart had, through a lifetime of Orthodox ascetic practice, become the beauty of his illumined face—better, his countenance. When St. Herman's ermine and bear beheld this beauty, they were nourished—directly *fed*—by the works of his beauty. And such beauty does not die.

In late August 1994, my wife Xenia, our son Rowan Benedict (then age fourteen), and I traveled to Kodiak, Alaska, to make a tiny pilgrimage to St. Herman's Spruce Island, in honor of the saint's arrival there in the autumn of

1794. Arriving at St. Herman's Orthodox Seminary in Kodiak, where we were to stay, we asked the administrator if there was any way to reach Spruce Island. "Today?" he asked (it was now past noon), shaking his head. "I doubt it, but I'll go see." Mostly silently, we began to unpack our few things and to arrange our icons. We had come six thousand miles. "Perhaps tomorrow we can find a way over," we said.

Then there came a sharp knock on the door. A small but stocky Aleut man stood there. "Do you want to go see Father Herman?" he asked. Our hearts lifted.

Down at the water, two short blocks away, his little craft was beached. Spruce Island was visible some five miles over now calm ocean. Our guide—named Herman, as we might have expected, after the saint—pointed out across the water. "Look at that! Father Herman wants you to come, he's made the water all calm." We clambered into the boat, and Herman shoved us off and then started the motor.

The boat throttled down as we nosed into a small lagoon—Monk's Lagoon, it's called. I looked down. The bottom was rising toward us. Herman said, "I got to drop anchor pretty soon now." A few seconds later, the concrete-block anchor splashed into maybe twenty inches of water. The boat's prow was nearly three yards from the shore.

"We got to jump to shore," said Herman. "From up there on the deck," waving us up.

Our fourteen-year-old son went first, jumping the gap gracefully. Then my wife jumped, going down to her hands and knees as she landed—on dry land. Then I climbed up on the deck. And all at once I felt every one of my fifty-four years and all the gracelessness of my academic life. Then I heard Herman's voice on my left side. He was standing in water above his knees next to the boat. He said, "Come on, get on my back, I'll carry you."

I flushed, embarrassed. "Oh, no, I weigh over 170 pounds."

"Oh, come on," he said. "I carry packs heavier than you."

So I settled myself onto Herman's back. Not since my two sons had, at different points in their childhood, tried to carry me had I been actually carried by someone. Weeks later, as I told my priest of this moment, he smiled, "It's always so. Whenever you visit a holy place, God arranges for a surprise. The real miracle is that you let yourself be carried." I had traveled six thousand miles in order to be carried by someone for the final three yards. It is always so: in every ascetic action we must let go of all our own control.

We made our way up the beach and into the woods toward the church, our son striding ahead, followed by Herman, and my wife and I a little

behind them. Then it came to us, to both of us at once: an indescribably sweet odor at once powerful and gentle, an odor like nothing in this world. Our eyes quickly scanned the forest of moss-covered evergreen and found nothing in bloom. We turned to each other. On my wife's face I read perfect joy.

Herman had stopped. "You coming?"

"What's that amazing odor?" I asked, filled with a trembling delight.

"Oh," said Herman, stepping back toward us, his dark-gold face lit in smiling. "That's Father Herman, some folks notice it, that's the land remembering him."

Since that August moment in 1994, Herman's response has come to hold for me much of what the Orthodox Church knows as imperishable joy in the creation: that's the land remembering him. Incorruptibly remembering.

In his remarkable book *Beyond the Shattered Image*, Fr. John Chryssavgis devotes a chapter to a subject very dear to Russian religious philosophy: the subject of Sophia, or Wisdom. Father John offers this luminous definition of the cosmological function of Sophia:

> It is the bridge between God and the World, belonging to and uniting both realities at once. . . . It is also the divine Wisdom whose seeds and traces may be found in the multiplicity of creation. . . . *One in God, she is many in creation*, was the way Florensky described *sophia*.[8]

This mystery of oneness and multiplicity is, of course, the central mystery of creation. And the Orthodox faith calls us to one primary relation to such mystery: attentiveness, watchfulness, alertness.

As an image of such alertness, I offer this marvelous narrative by the nature writer Annie Dillard. She was sitting on a tree trunk by a pond, relaxed, when a bright bird flew from her right to a point behind her, and she swiveled around. "And," she continues, "the next instant, inexplicably, I was looking down at a weasel, who was looking up at me."

> Weasel! I'd never seen one wild before. He was ten inches long, thin as a curve, a muscled ribbon, brown as fruitwood, soft-furred, alert. His face was fierce, small and pointed as a lizard's; he would have made a good arrowhead. There was just a dot of chin, maybe two brown hairs' worth, and then the pure white fur began that spread down his underside. He had two black eyes I didn't see, any more than you see a window.
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> The weasel was stunned into stillness as he was emerging from beneath an enormous shaggy wild rose bush four feet away. I was stunned

> into stillness twisted backward on the tree trunk. Our eyes locked, and someone threw away the key.
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> Our look was as if two lovers, or deadly enemies, met unexpectedly on an overgrown path when each had been thinking of something else: a clearing blow to the gut. It was also a bright blow to the brain, or a sudden beating of brains, with all the charge and intimate grate of rubbed balloons. It emptied our lungs. It felled the forest, moved the fields, and drained the pond; the world dismantled and tumbled into that black hole of eyes. If you and I looked at each other that way, our skulls would split and drop to our shoulders. But we don't. We keep our skulls. So.
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> He disappeared. This was only last week, and already I don't remember what shattered the enchantment. I think I blinked, I think I retrieved my brain from the weasel's brain, and tried to memorize what I was seeing, and the weasel felt the yank of separation, the careening splashdown into real life and the urgent current of instinct. He vanished under the wild rose. I waited motionless, my mind suddenly full of data and my spirit with pleadings, but he didn't return.
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> Please do not tell me about "approach-avoidance conflicts." I tell you I've been in that weasel's brain for sixty seconds, and he was in mine. Brains are private places, muttering through unique and secret tapes—but the weasel and I both plugged into another tape simultaneously, for a sweet and shocking time.[9]

Such a moment of contact—sweet, shocking, and unforgettable—is precisely what every Orthodox liturgy calls us into. The priest chants, "Peace be unto all," and the choir sings "And to your spirit." Then the priest chants: "Let us love one another, that with one mind we may confess"—an incomplete sentence; confess *what*? The choir sings the sentence's completion: "Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, the Trinity, one in essence and undivided." The deacon then intones: "The doors, the doors!"—meaning, keep the doors that are now opening between heaven and earth free from every attack, human or demonic—and the deacon then chants: "In wisdom let us attend." Then we all sing the Creed.

My point is this: What the Orthodox Liturgy is calling us into is precisely the sweet and shocking contact with the mind and countenance of Christ. Our way into that contact is through loving one another so alertly and so entirely that we achieve *one-mindedness*—a condition, to use Dillard's phrase, that has "all the charge and intimate grate of rubbed balloons." But unlike her encounter with the weasel, our contact with Christ doesn't end with His vanishing under the wild rose.

Or perhaps more accurately: our contact with Him *shouldn't* end the moment we turn away from the chalice at communion. For Dillard's weasel vanishing away from us is what St. Herman's mother ermine becomes when our turning away becomes—as Dillard says—a "yank of separation." And there is only one way in the world to sustain the intimate contact that Christ calls us into: the way of Orthodox ascetic practice that St. Herman of Alaska so beautifully shows, the way of giving oneself entirely to and for another, in the sovereign action of ascetic love. And this way is the call into the undying heart of all creation. "Take, eat, this is My body . . . Drink, this is My blood."